

Mu Herculis
3 Suns

Zeta Herculis
8 Suns

Delta Herculis
26 Suns

HERCULES

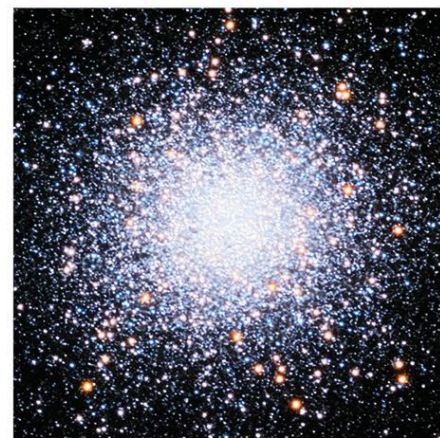
THE STRONGMAN

HERCULES IS A LARGE BUT NOT PARTICULARLY PROMINENT CONSTELLATION LYING BETWEEN LYRA AND BOÖTES. ITS MOST NOTABLE FEATURES ARE GLOBULAR STAR CLUSTERS, INCLUDING M13, WHICH IS GENERALLY REGARDED AS THE FINEST IN NORTHERN SKIES.

Hercules is oriented with his feet pointing north and his head in the south. He represents the strongman of ancient Greek mythology who was ordered to undertake 12 epic labors. Among them was slaying a dragon, and in the sky Hercules is visualized with his left foot over the dragon's head, represented by the constellation Draco to the north. Hercules's head is marked by the star called Rasalgethi, which is a red giant of variable brightness. Although Rasalgethi is labeled Alpha Herculis, the constellation's brightest star is Beta Herculis, also known as Kornephoros.

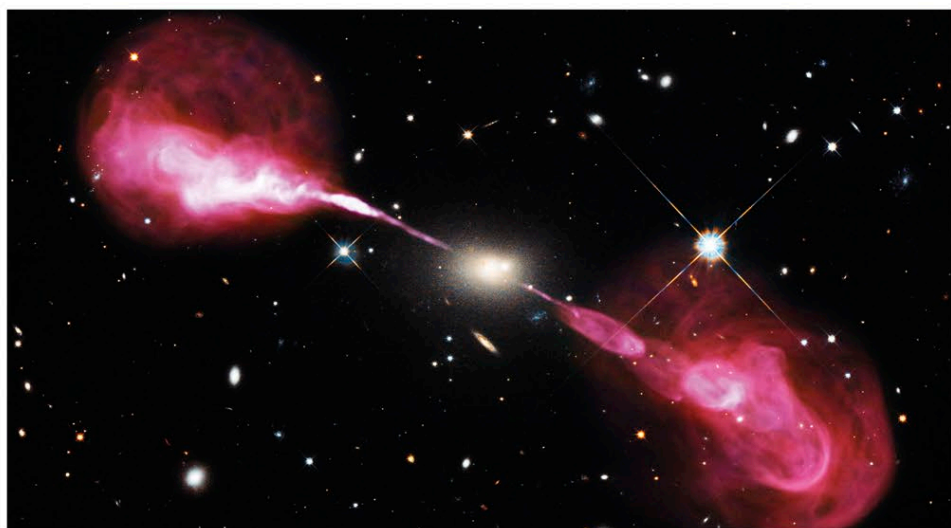
Four of the constellation's pattern stars (Epsilon, Zeta, Eta, and Pi Herculis) form a quadrangular shape called the Keystone. The Keystone marks the lower body of Hercules. On one side of the Keystone lies the bright globular cluster M13, which is nearly 150 light-years across and contains more than one-quarter of a million stars.

Hercules also contains several attractive double stars that can be separated with the use of a small telescopes, notably Rho Herculis, 95 Herculis, and a relatively bright and nearby white dwarf, 110 Herculis.



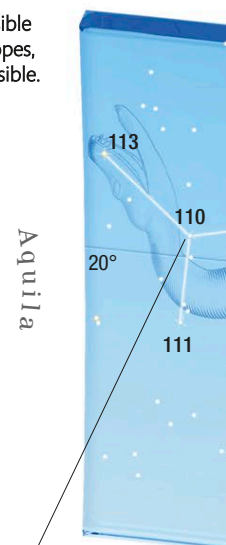
△ M13

The brightest globular cluster in the northern sky, M13 lies about 25,000 light-years away and contains an estimated 300,000 stars. It is just visible to the naked eye; with small telescopes, details such as chains of stars are visible.



◁ Hercules A

Jets of gas a million light-years long shoot out from Hercules A, an elliptical galaxy about two billion light-years away. Although invisible at visible-light wavelengths, the jets can be detected at radio wavelengths and can be seen clearly in this combined visible-light and radio-wave image. The jets are thought to be powered by a black hole with a mass of about 2.5 billion Suns at the galaxy's center.



110 Herculis

White dwarf about 63 light-years away. With a magnitude of 4.2, it is visible with the naked eye.

▷ Star distances

The nearest of Hercules's main pattern stars, Mu (μ) Herculis, is only 27 light-years away while the farthest is Theta (θ) Herculis, at about 758 light-years. Coincidentally, these are also the least and most luminous of the pattern stars. Mu emits as much energy as about three Suns whereas Theta emits the equivalent of about 1,330 Suns.

